Chapter 4: Architecture Definition

Study Guide, based on Mastering the TOGAF Standard by Eric Jager (2025), Chapter 4 (pp. 53-62)

Overview

Chapter 4 (pp. 53-62) asks what Enterprise Architecture actually *is*, and shows that even the TOGAF Standard does not settle on one answer. Section 4.1 gives the Standard's ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022-based definition and its supplementary second sentence, then argues that a key element is missing: the link to business objectives (pp. 54-56). Section 4.2 separates Enterprise Architecture from IT Architecture (p. 57). Section 4.3 shows that the Standard effectively uses three definitions: ISO, Gartner (via the Leader's Guide), and FEAPO (via the BIZBOK Guide) (pp. 58-61). Section 4.4 summarizes (pp. 61-62). Leave with this idea: because no single definitive definition exists, each organization must define how *it* practices EA, so there is no internal ambiguity (pp. 61, 62). Chapter 4 is part of the PINK and GREEN reading tours (p. 53).

> **Reading note:** The quoted definitions come from the Standard, the Leader's Guide (Gartner), and BIZBOK (FEAPO). Jager's own views are: the Standard's definition lacks the business-objective link (p. 55), his own description of EA as "a framework for understanding and managing the overall structure and strategy" (p. 56), the claim that there is "absolutely nothing technical" to EA (p. 57), and his worry that the 2008 Gartner definition is outdated (p. 58).

Detailed Section Breakdown

Chapter Opener (p. 53)

- **Why definitions matter.** A definition gives an unambiguous description. Leaving room for interpretation creates different perceptions "with all the consequences that entails" (p. 53).

4.1 What Is Enterprise Architecture (pp. 54-56)

- **The Standard's definition (ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022, adopted with Technical Corrigendum 1, 2025).** "The fundamental concepts or properties of an entity in its environment and governing principles for the realization and evolution of this entity and its related lifecycle processes" (p. 54).
- **The supplementary "second definition".** "The structure of components, their interrelationships, and the principles and guidelines governing their design and evolution over time" (p. 54).
- **What they imply together.** Architecture defines the characteristics of a system, and frameworks surround the system to oversee its development (p. 54).
- **"System" is broad.** In TOGAF, "system" is not limited to an IT system. It can be an enterprise, something larger, or something as small as a project, which leaves plenty of room for interpretation (p. 54).
- **Greenslade's 2003 definition.** Chris Greenslade (then Chairman of The Open Group) defined (IT) architecture as "the fundamental organization of a system, embodied in its components, their relationships to each other and the environment, and the principles governing its design and evolution", practically represented in Architectural Descriptions from stakeholders' viewpoints (p. 55).
- **The missing component.** The current definition lacks the relation to achieving business objectives. EA must ensure that objectives and intended results are achieved, and it must ensure coherence from organizational structures to information systems and from capabilities to applications (p. 55).

Jager's commentary (author's view): EA "is perhaps best described as a framework for understanding and managing the overall structure and strategy of an organization". It creates a holistic view of business processes, information systems, and technology, keeps them coherent, aligns them to goals, resolves inconsistencies, and enables planning for growth (p. 56).

4.2 Confusion Over Definitions (p. 57)

	Enterprise Architecture	IT Architecture
Purpose	Enables the organization to achieve its goals and objectives, realizing its strategy	Far more technical in nature
Answers	Stakeholder concerns and questions about the portfolio or specific projects	Technical design questions
Diagrams and matrices	Answer stakeholders' questions. They do not illustrate technical solutions	Illustrate technical solutions
Role	Oversees all domains (Technology is one) and coordinates. A "strategic business management tool"	Executes the Technology Architecture (IT Architects)

- **Why the confusion exists.** EA originated "in the technology corner" (see Ch. 2, Section 2.2), and the two are still lumped together (p. 57).
- **No ultimate definition.** The Standard's definition is one of many, which is perhaps why even the Standard uses more than one (p. 57).

Jager's commentary (author's view): The two are "as different as night and day", and "there is absolutely nothing technical to Enterprise Architecture" (p. 57).

4.3 Multiple Definitions (pp. 58-61)

#	Source in TOGAF	Original author	Definition (abridged)	Page
1	Core Concepts (Fundamental Content)	ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022	Fundamental concepts/properties of an entity in its environment, plus governing principles for its realization and evolution	pp. 54, 58
2	Leader's Guide (Series Guide)	Gartner (2008)	"The process of translating business vision and strategy into effective enterprise change by creating, communicating, and improving the key principles and models that describe the enterprise's future state and enable its evolution"	p. 58
3	BIZBOK Guide (referenced body of knowledge)	FEAPO	"The holistic planning, analysis, design, and implementation for the development and execution of strategy by applying principles and practices to guide organizations through the integration and interoperation of all other architecture domains"	p. 60

- **Figure 4-1, how to read it.** EA at the centre. Around it are the organizations that define it (The Open Group, Business Architecture Guild, FEAPO, Gartner, ISO). Blue = sources where definitions are found. Yellow = specific references. Purple = the definitions of EA, Business Architecture, or Architecture (pp. 59).
- **What the FEAPO definition gets right.** It links EA to developing and executing strategy, and therefore to business goals and objectives, which the Standard's own definition lacks (p. 60).
- **The apple analogy.** "A round piece of fruit with a stem" could equally describe a cherry or a grape. Definitions keep us from "comparing apples and oranges" (pp. 60-61).
- **Conclusion.** EA manifests at different levels and in different ways, so it resists a single definition. Organizations must define how they practice EA (p. 61).

Jager's commentary (author's view): Using a 2008 definition in a framework updated in 2025 "might raise a few eyebrows". It may be outdated or superseded (p. 58).

4.4 Summary (pp. 61-62)

- **Three definitions in one standard:** ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022-based (the Standard adds a second sentence to complete it), Gartner via the Leader's Guide, and FEAPO via the BIZBOK Guide (pp. 61-62).
- The Standard's own definition misses the realization of business goals. The Gartner definition risks being outdated. The BIZBOK/FEAPO definition is adopted indirectly because TOGAF refers to BIZBOK for Business Architecture (p. 62).
- **Takeaway.** Define how EA is practiced in your organization to avoid ambiguity (p. 62).

Key Terms & Definitions

Term	Definition	Page
Architecture (TOGAF / ISO 42010:2022)	Fundamental concepts or properties of an entity in its environment and governing principles for its realization and evolution and related lifecycle processes	p. 54
Architecture (TOGAF supplement)	The structure of components, their interrelationships, and the principles and guidelines governing their design and evolution over time	p. 54
System	In TOGAF, any entity: an enterprise, something larger, or a project. Not just an IT system	p. 54
Enterprise Architecture (Gartner)	Translating business vision and strategy into effective enterprise change via principles and models of the future state	p. 58
Enterprise Architecture (FEAPO/BIZBOK)	Holistic planning, analysis, design, and implementation for developing and executing strategy across all architecture domains	p. 60
IT Architecture	A far more technical discipline that executes Technology Architecture, coordinated by EA	p. 57
FEAPO	Federation of Enterprise Architecture Professional Organizations	p. 59

Figures & Tables Referenced

Figure / Table	What it shows	Page
Figure 4-1	The many definitions of EA and their source organizations and documents	p. 59

Self-Check Questions

Q: Which external standard does the TOGAF Standard's definition of architecture come from, and since when?

A: ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022, adopted with Technical Corrigendum 1 (2025) (p. 54).

Q: What key element does Jager say is missing from the Standard's definition?

A: Its relation to achieving business objectives, i.e., EA ensuring that goals and intended results are realized (pp. 55, 62).

Q: What can "system" mean in the TOGAF definition?

A: An enterprise, something even larger, or something smaller such as a project. It is not limited to IT systems (p. 54).

Q: List the three EA definitions used within the TOGAF Standard and where each comes from.

A: (1) The ISO/IEC/IEEE 42010:2022-based definition in Core Concepts; (2) Gartner's 2008 definition in the Leader's Guide; (3) FEAPO's definition via the BIZBOK Guide (pp. 61-62).

Q: Why does the FEAPO definition appeal to Jager?

A: It ties EA explicitly to the development and execution of strategy, and so to business goals, which the Standard's definition lacks (p. 60).

Q: How does EA differ from IT Architecture?

A: EA enables the organization to achieve its goals and strategy, oversees and coordinates all domains, and answers stakeholder concerns. IT Architecture is technical and executes the Technology Architecture (p. 57).

Q: What is the point of the apple analogy?

A: A loose description ("round fruit with a stem") fits cherries and grapes too. Precise definitions are needed to know what something is and is not (pp. 60-61).

Q: Given that no definitive definition exists, what does the chapter recommend?

A: Define how EA is practiced or represented in your own organization so that there is no internal ambiguity (pp. 61-62).

Q: Why does Jager question the Gartner definition?

A: It dates from 2008 yet appears in a framework updated in 2025, so it may be outdated or superseded (p. 58).

Q: How did Greenslade's 2003 definition say architecture is represented in practice?

A: In Architectural Descriptions from the viewpoints of the stakeholders (p. 55).